SAMPLE

The Hunted Outlaw

The Personality That Runs With Its Crime

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Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The chase log starts onto its most *unresolved* exhibit: the self whose whole biography is a departure — the colleague's entry, entered with the admiration the pursuit log has learned to hear underneath it: *he was the best hire we ever made — better than anyone knew, and he knew that better than anyone — and one day the offer came from the big office, the corner, the title, the whole arrival, and he was gone before the month was out, and we never got an address that lasted* — the room, declined, *by winning*, in one sentence.

The creed quoted — the friend's entry, held with love and one permanent question: *he calls himself the freest person I know, and he believes it — and I have watched him check the exits of every restaurant we have ever shared, and I have never once watched him sit with his back to the door* — and the wound the chase log cannot close, the first crime scene — the wanted poster: a deed *done* — justified, or not; the pursuit log has both kinds, and the type remembers the justification either way — and the discovery, made at the scene of it and never once revised: *freedom and guilt can be carried in the same pair of legs* — the self, fled, and the deed, *kept* — the running that began as escape becoming, quietly, over the years, a *residence* — and the chase log's founding finding set down in the ink the whole book lives in: the Hunted Outlaw is this catalog's most *mobile* self — a life of new towns, warm aliases, the horse always ready — and the whole case turns on the finding: the flight was the *escape* — and the flight, the whole file will show, is also the *sentence* — a self serving time in motion, prosecuted nightly by the only pursuer that never lost the trail: the self.

This is a case file on the Hunted Outlaw: the personality that runs with its crime, freedom with a price.

The first crime scene is the deed done, and the pursuit log marks what makes it this catalog's most *self-authored* origin: this is the one constitution built by an *act* — not a wound received, not a script imposed: the deed, committed by the type's own hand — the lie told to save the family; the score settled; the rule broken in daylight, on principle, with witnesses; the betrayal, committed or merely *caused* — and the type, remembering it, does not always remember it with guilt; the pursuit log must be honest: some cases remember the deed as *justice — it needed doing and no one else would* — and some remember it as the day the self became *unbelievable to itself* — and both kinds share the one clause the scene wrote, the clause that becomes both the gift and the shadow: *they will come for me* — the pursuit, assumed, permanent, whether or not the pursuit ever actually existed — because the deed, done, taught the

child the lesson that structures the whole biography: *the world has sheriffs* — acts have consequences, and consequences have *jurisdiction* — and the self that cannot face the consequence has exactly one freedom left: *distance* — and the running, so free from outside, was thus the plainest custody in this catalog: the self, released on its own recognizance, reporting to *no one*, and *running anyway*.

And what was the engine for? The pursuit log answers with the tenderness every case deserves: the young self was solving for *unpossessedness* — the discovery, made at the scene of the deed, was not that the world was cruel but that the self had become *evidence*: the deed, carried, made every room conditional — the town, unsafe; the name, an alias's host; the past, a jurisdiction the type dragged like a chain behind a moving train — and the child's solution, so costly and so honest: *if the self cannot be acquitted, the self can be unfindable* — and the solution worked; the pursuit log is unambiguous: the Hunted Outlaw *escapes*, reliably, spectacularly — the pursuit, outrun; the town, outgrown; the name, retired like a coat — and the bill arrives exactly where the escape's math predicted it would not: the freedom, purchased with distance, is *denominated in the past* — every mile spent buying it is a mile the deed chose — and the type, the chase log has measured it across every biography, is never freer than the day of arrival in a new town and never less free than the night after — because the running, continued past every pursuer, has become the *sentence self-administered* — time served in motion — the type's name kept moving so the past cannot find a fixed address, and the past, the whole file will show, does not need one: it has a *carrier*.

And the chase log must enter the engine's cruelest economy, because it is the indictment's whole hinge: *the flight postpones the verdict* — and postponement is the only verdict flight can deliver — the deed, done, requires the one proceeding the legs cannot conduct: a *judgment* — guilty, innocent, justified, forgiven, *something* — and the type, having fled the court where the judgment was pending, carries the docket open through every new town — and the chase log's central line on the indictment: the outlaw does not fear being caught; the outlaw fears being *tried* — being stopped, held still, and asked the question the legs have outrun since the scene: *what did you do, and was it right?* — because the flight, whatever it costs, never has to *answer* — and the growth's whole discovery, arriving ten chapters early so the type can practice standing in it: the verdict the self fled was never the world's to render — the world, the pursuit log has found, mostly stopped chasing years ago; the pursuit, continued so faithfully, is *staffed entirely from inside* — and the indictment the whole book builds toward is the indictment's quietest

proceeding: the deed, finally judged — by the only court left, the self's own, in session at a fixed address — and the freedom, discovered at the end of it, that was available *standing still* all along.

If you are this type, the book's wager is exact: you have the strongest *legs* in this catalog, and the chase log holds the proof — the rooms escaped, the fresh starts mastered, the whole life rebuilt from a saddlebag more times than most selves rebuild from a fortune — and the pursuit log's question, held across ten chapters and asked flat-out here so you can try standing in it: *what are you still running from — the posse, or the question?* — because the chase log's answer, in every case, is the finding the constitution guards most closely: *the pursuit's headcount* — the type, asked who is chasing, cannot name a pursuer that has appeared in the last decade — the warrants, expired; the witnesses, moved on; the town, rebuilt — and the chase, continued without a chaser, is the chase log's definition of the *sentence*: guilt, self-administered, served nightly in motion — and the chase log's plainest line on the indictment: the escape was never the sin; the *unexamined* escape was; the legs, so loyal, have been carrying the self away from a courtroom that has been standing empty for years, waiting — and the self, once it stops, becomes what it always resembled from a distance and never quite let itself be: not a fugitive — a *citizen*, the word's whole meaning: the name, held, at an address, *findable* — and the past, at last, knockable-on.

If you love one, your instructions are precise and counterintuitive: do not chase — the pursuit, joined, confirms the first crime scene's physics and buys the type's absence for another season; and do not offer sanctuary — the rescue, being a *shelter from consequence*, reenacts the crime's aftermath, and the type accepts the shelter and leaves it, both on schedule; the instruction that works, and the chase log has tested it: *hold the address* — be the fixed point the type can return to, unchanged, unchasing, for as long as the sentence runs — because the Hunted Outlaw has never once, in any file, fled a person who asked *no questions and kept the porch light on* — and the question, the whole file will show, is the one experience this constitution fled: being *found*, and not condemned — which is the beginning of the growth: the self, at last, standing *still* for the verdict it has carried since the deed.

Turn the page. The Hunted Outlaw is still out there — mid-flight, mid-alias, mid-freedom that costs its own weight nightly — and the pursuit log's promise is the chase log's plainest: the road was never the sin; the *unjudged* deed was; and the self, once the verdict is finally rendered and the running ends, becomes what it always resembled from a distance: not the one who got away — the one who finally *came back*, and stood, and answered — and the horse, at last, allowed to *rest*.

And the pursuit log opens its own proceedings with one instruction to the reader, because the indictment requires it: this is the one volume in the catalog that must be read *twice* — once as a pursuit story, which is how it will read on the first pass, with the type running from town to town ahead of a pursuit the reader can feel closing in — and once as a *sentencing story*, which is how it reads once the chase log's central finding has landed: the pursuit, so vivid, was never staffed — the sheriffs retired decades ago, the victims of the original deed, the chase log has traced them, mostly forgave or forgot, and the only officer still working the indictment rides in the type's own chest — and the reader who takes the second pass will see what the pursuit log saw in every biography: the running was never *from* the world; the running was from the *verdict* — the world's simplest, kindest proceeding, the one every other self in the catalog sits for and survives: *what did you do, and was it right?* — and the indictment's wager, entered as the pursuit log's last founding line: the reader who is this type has checked the exits of this paragraph twice already — and the reader who loves this type has never once needed to check anything, because the type, for all the leaving, has been the same self in every town — and the book's quiet promise to both: there is, at the end of these ten chapters, a *courtroom* — patient, unstaffed by anyone but the self, open continuously for decades — and the trial it holds is the only one in the chase log the type has ever actually *wanted*, underneath everything: the trial where the defendant finally sits still, and the verdict, whatever it is, is *rendered* — because the pursuit log has read the ending of every biography brave enough to hold it, and the verdict, in every single one, reads the same: *time already served — case closed — the defendant is free to go home.*

Chapter 1: The Signature — the Hunted Outlaw at a Glance

Before anyone speaks, the room's exits have already been *counted* — and the pursuit log must open with the honest fact that makes this type so magnetic and so unreachable: the Hunted Outlaw is *live flight* — not restlessness for its own sake, though it goes about in that coat: the person whose attention, on entering any room, goes first to the *doors* — how many, which way they open, whether the window behind the table is a door too — and then, only then, to the people; and the signature, the pursuit log has learned to clock it in the first ten minutes or so of any room: watch the seat — the Hunted Outlaw never once sits with the back to the entrance, not at dinner, not at work, not at the wedding of a favorite cousin — the wall at the type's back, the room in the type's sightline, the body angled, always, like a compass needle pointed at *away* — and the sentence, deployed when the world asks the type to *stay*, the

pursuit log has collected it verbatim in every case: *I was never planning to stay long anyway* — the farewell, pre-loaded, and the chase log's note: the type says it leaving rooms the type *loved*.

The manner carries the flight, and the pursuit log must render it exactly, because it is so often mistaken for adventure: the Hunted Outlaw is not merely a wanderer — in conversation the type is warm, quick, genuinely present, *better* company than the settled, because presence, in the type's economy, is an item spent rather than kept — the charge arrives only at the *ask to stay*: the lease, the title, the vow, the *spring* — the type's whole weather changes at permanence, the smile, kept, and the eyes, already measuring the door — and the chase log's testimony, gathered from the loved ones of every case, is word for word the same in every file: *he is the most alive person I know and the least here* — I have loved him for fifteen years and I could not tell you his real name — said with love, and the pursuit log's sharp note: both halves are true — and the second one is the *bill*.

And underneath the live flight runs the tell the type's loved ones report and the type never sees: the *nightly audit* — the Hunted Outlaw's quiet, permanent arithmetic of the deed: the scene, replayed at the day's end with the thoroughness of a clerk closing a register — the choice, re-made; the justification, re-tested; the question, asked in the dark, *was it worth it? — and the chase log's correction: the type does not experience the audit as guilt, exactly; the type experiences it as bookkeeping* — the debt, carried, and the running, the payment plan — and the people near the Hunted Outlaw live the way people live beside a river: everything is always moving, and nothing can be built on the bank — the whole room sensing, correctly, that the freest person present is also the *least finished* — which is the indictment's own quiet arithmetic: the escape, decades old, and the verdict, still *pending* — the legs, so loyal, and the courtroom, never once convened.

The pursuit log holds two versions of the origin, both of them true, and they converge on the same reading.

The dramatic version — the chase log finds it in about half the indictments, and the type tells it the way scripture is told: the deed, *public* — the act, witnessed, the line crossed in daylight: the score settled that everyone knew was owed; the rule broken on behalf of somebody too small to break it; the betrayal, committed by the type's own hand, or merely *blamed on* it — and the pursuit, real: the town that closed against the type; the family name, handed to the type like a sentence; the door, not slammed but *locked*, because the deed had made the self, in the town's law, *unkeepable* — and the departure, administered like a sacrament: *I will be free — somewhere else*.

The quiet version — the pursuit log finds it in the other half, and it becomes the subtler origin because the deed was never *charged*: no posse; the act, unseen or unprosecuted — the lie told that saved the family's standing; the robbery, committed for a sibling's medicine; the abandonment, the leaving itself as the crime, a debt of presence walked out on — and the type, pursued by nothing but the *knowledge*, discovers the quieter warrant: the self's own *conscience*, deputized by the deed, and the pursuit, staffed entirely from inside — and the quiet version, the chase log notes, is the harder origin precisely because the flight cannot be *won*: an outside posse can be outrun; a deputized conscience rides *with* the type, in the same coat, holding the same map.

And the two versions converge, the pursuit log has verified, in the signature that identifies the type at a glance: the deed is *remembered, not disputed* — the type does not plead innocence to the chase log; the type pleads *justification*, and the pleading, the pursuit log has learned, is the tell — the justification, rehearsed so often it has become the type's *creed* — the freedom, quoted like a license purchased with the deed — and, the chase log's tender finding, the type has never once been heard to *conclude* the story: the deed, told, and the flight, told — and the ending, always, *pending* — the self, mid-story for a lifetime, and the last page, unwritten because unfaceable — which is the whole case in one detail: the deed, survived, and the self, built to never once be *still enough* to read its own verdict.

The hideout album opens on the scene the type names first, and the pursuit log has learned to let it be told without interruption: the *deed's threshold* — the moment, always early, when the child learned that acts are *unforgettable* — the window broken to save the cat, punished anyway; the confession told, and disbelieved, or believed, and never mentioned again; the small lie that worked so well it frightened the child more than being caught would have — and the pursuit log's crucial observation, made in every album: the child discovered, at the threshold, that *consequence is not proportionate* — the act and the world's answer do not match, and the mismatch is *terrifying*: a thing done in a second can be *owed* for a lifetime — and the child's answer, the hideout album's first artifact: *never be where the bill can find you*.

The hideout album holds the *first flight* — the chase log finds it in every case, and it is always smaller than the grown type's retelling suggests, which is the finding: the runaway afternoon at eight; the friend's house, slept at without asking; the bedroom window, practiced like a fire drill — the child, testing the one power the deed taught: *the power to be elsewhere* — and the hideout album's most reliable artifact: the child was not fleeing *danger*; the child was fleeing *proceeding* — the dinner where the thing would be discussed; the

school where the note had been sent; the room where the adults would *sit the child down* — the pursuit log's note, entered gently: the type's whole biography is the child's discovery, scaled: it is not consequences the type flees; it is *trials* — being held still, and asked, and *judged* — and the running, begun at eight, was the child's one legal remedy against the courtroom of childhood: *the door*.

The hideout album holds the *warmth on the road* — the detail the grown type smiles at and the pursuit log holds carefully: the child, elsewhere, was *beloved* — the aunt's house, the summer camp, the friend's family that seemed to keep a better copy of the child than the child's own house kept — and the chase log's note, entered with both hands: this is the hideout album's most dangerous page, because it taught the type the lesson that structures the whole biography: *new places love me* — belonging, experienced only at *first* — the welcome, warmest at the door, and the type, learning to read the road as the only place where the self is *in good standing* — and the hideout album's quiet counterpart, the scene the type does not name but the loved ones always do: the *second winter* — the camp, attended twice, and the magic, gone; the friend's family, visited again, and the type, now a *guest* rather than a wonder — the chase log's x-ray: the type has loved the first town of every place and never once stayed for the second — the discovery, made early, that the welcome *expires* — and the conclusion, minted in the hideout album's last page and never once revised: *love is an arrival-time phenomenon; leave before it becomes a trial*.

And the hideout album closes on the *creed*, minted in the language of the age: *they can't catch what won't stay* — and the pursuit log's finding on the creed, the finding the whole case turns on: it was kept — and the child, keeping it, mistook it for a *freedom* when it was a *sentence* — the can't-catch, permanent, and the won't-stay, the *clause* that made it so — the type's whole mobility, the chase log notes, built as a legal defense, and the self, so free from outside, *unfree at the center* — which is the hideout album's last page and the pursuit log's first finding: the Hunted Outlaw does not have a travel *problem*; the type has a *verdict* problem — the road was never the issue; the issue is the courtroom waiting at the end of it, in session since the deed, in the only venue the type cannot leave: the self.

Energy: motion — the type runs on *distance*: the new horizon, the first week anywhere, the departure itself — and the pursuit log's honest spec: the Hunted Outlaw's energy peaks at the *leaving* — the road, under the type, is the native weather; the *staying*, the chase log notes, is where the type is restless, already hearing the question the staying will eventually ask: *and who are you, staying?*

Ambition: the *unfindable* — the type does not want the throne or even, mostly, the wealth; the type wants the *clean horizon* — and the chase log's dry note: the ambition is pursued by *lightness*: the résumé, kept portable; the possessions, kept sellable; the name, kept optional — and the world's most mobile self, in pursuit of a stillness it has never once let itself be caught by.

Vanity structure: the *escape* — the pride is in the *never caught* — the pursuit, outrun; the room, walked out of with the best lines; the *no one owns me*, deployed like a credential — and the pursuit log's x-ray: the vanity's secret clause reads that the flight *is* the identity — the type is quietly, deeply proud of being unhuntable, and the chase log's quiet note: the elusiveness is real; so is the fact that it was built to dodge a *trial* — the credential, kept current, for a proceeding that was never scheduled by anyone but the self.

Loyalty: to the *road-people* — the Hunted Outlaw keeps, for decades, the ones met in motion: the stranger who shared the last stretch of highway; the colleague of the one crazy year; the friend made in the new town, kept by letters across every town since — and the chase log's driest note: the loyalty's blind side is its *hostility to address*: the type will keep the person and lose the *place* — the friendship, renewed in each new town at the same bar's kind of distance, forever *warm and elsewhere* — the relationship surviving every geography and never once surviving a *lease*.

Weakness: the *verdict* — the one proceeding the type cannot hold: the deed, judged — the question, *was it right?*, answered — the type's own court, never once convened, because convening it requires the one thing the constitution forbids: *standing still long enough to hear the evidence*.

Unspoken need: to be *acquitted* — the one experience the type has never had: the deed, examined, and the self, *forgiven or sentenced and either way finished* — the trial, survived, and the verdict, *worn* like citizenship — and the need the constitution guards like a contradiction, because in this biography's language, the courtroom is the *end of the road* — and the counterevidence — that the verdict is the *beginning* of it, that a self can only carry a home once the docket is closed — has never once been allowed to exist.

At a party. The room's *comet* — the Hunted Outlaw at a party is the guest the *gladness* runs toward: the entrance, late and warm; the jokes, minted on arrival; the whole room lit for the duration — and the pursuit log's sharp detail: the type's *magnetism* — the chase log has measured it across every case — peaks at the *arrival* and the *performance*, and collapses, quietly, at the *third hour* — the chase log's line: the Hunted Outlaw is the best two hours any party ever had, and the host's honest report: *nobody could tell you when he left* — and the tell is in the departure: the type leaves *at the peak of being loved* —

the goodbye, never staged, the coat, gone before the room noticed — because the third hour, the pursuit log knows, is where the *questions* begin: *so what do you do — where are you from — how long are you in town?* — the interrogation the type reads in any other pair of hands.

In a new job. Instant *brilliance* — the Hunted Outlaw's first quarter is the chase log's most *dazzling*: the learning, faster than the institution has ever seen; the problems, solved with the strange ease of a self that has *rebuilt a life from nothing* more times than the institution has reorganized; the charm, aimed at the whole floor — and the chase log's most reliable workplace finding: the type is, by month six, the most *valued* person in the building and the last one to have signed the benefits paperwork — the type, the pursuit log has learned, works like a self with *no succession in the plan* — the chase log's arithmetic: the contribution, enormous; the cost, the *continuity* — because the institution, the whole file notes, promotes on *accumulated trust*, and the type has left every trust account closed before the interest could accrue — the one meeting the type has never once taken: the annual review, *held in a town the type still lives in*.

Under sudden pressure. The type's *native weather*, and the chase log enters it with genuine awe: the Hunted Outlaw in a crisis is the catalog's most *unflappable* presence — the evacuation, organized like a square dance; the collapse, met with the calm of a self whose whole childhood rehearsed it — where others freeze at the sudden loss of the *plan*, the type relaxes: the crisis, being nobody's *trial*, is just *weather*, and the type moves through it like a homecoming — and the pursuit log's most delicate finding: the emergency is the only room where the type stands *still* — planted, steady, the last one out — the chase log's line: the world gets this type's most *present* self in its worst moments — the fact the whole case turns on: the flight was never cowardice; it was *avoidance of one question* — and the question, the pursuit log notes, is not asked by any crisis, which is why the type is a hero in the flood and gone by the parade.

In a boring meeting. The *caged weather* — and the chase log's x-ray: the *horizon check* — the Hunted Outlaw in a settled meeting is the self at the *window*: the agenda, untouched; the clock, consulted like a border guard; the chair, angled already toward the door — and the type, at the appointed minute, volunteers for the *errand* — the run to the office across town, the client who needs the in-person visit, anything with *legs* — and the pursuit log's tender note: the type is not bored by the work; the type is bored by the *sitting* — the chair, in this constitution's physics, being a *holding cell* — and the chase log has never once watched a Hunted Outlaw take the seat at the table's *inside* row, the wall-side seat, the settled seat — the type, always, on the

room's edge, keeping the exit honest.

On holiday. The chase log's most *hopeful* finding for this case: the Hunted Outlaw on holiday is the catalog's most *fluent* self — and the finding's paradox is the chapter's sharpest: the holiday, for this type, is *indistinguishable from the biography* — the new town, mastered by Thursday; the strangers, family by Sunday; the farewell, warm and *complete* — the self, on the road, *at home* — and the tell is in the *reason* it works: the holiday removes the *trial* — a vacation town asks no questions, keeps no records, holds no court — and the road removed from consequence, the self surfaces — relaxed, funny, *whole* — the chase log's line on the pattern: the holiday does not remove the deed; it removes the *venue* — and the self, the whole file has found, is a person in there, settled and good company, that the flight never once let the world keep — the finding the whole case turns on: the freedom was never in the *moving*; it was in the *acquittal* the moving postponed — and the homecoming, the whole book will show, is the only trip the type has never once packed for.

The *Branded Outcast* (Volume 120) is the nearest confusion, and the pursuit log must draw it first because the shelf itself has paired them as the brand's two answers: both types were handed a verdict by a room, both live *outside* an inside, and both are fluent in the road — but the Outcast's sentence was written *about* the self: the exclusion, the label, the door — and the type answered it *inbound*: belonging as conquest, the room taken by credential; the Hunted Outlaw's sentence was written *by* the self: the deed, done by the type's own hand, the consequence, owed — and the type answered it *outbound*: flight as identity, the room declined by *distance* — the test: watch each of them offered the hometown's apology.

The Outcast books the visit the moment the career can carry it — the town, *confronted*; the arrival, *witnessed*. The Outlaw drives past at night — the town, *avoided*; the self, safer for the distance — and the border, dry and final: *the Outcast fights for the room; the Outlaw flees the courtroom* — and the pursuit log's closing note: the two types are the verdict's two verdicts — *appeal* and *bail* — and the chase log's warning to the Hunted Outlaw alone, because the Outcast's war, whatever it costs, at least *ends* with a seat: the flight, being a *postponement*, has no ending — no door is taken, no room is won; the type simply keeps not- answering — and the whole file will show: the question the type fled is the type's own, and it has been holding the hearing anyway, nightly, without the type's consent.

The *Fate-Breaker* (Volume 119) is the sibling confusion, the pursuit log's most *instructive*, because both types read as *freedom* and both keep a founding scene at arm's length: but the Fate-Breaker's founding scene was a *script* — a

future written for the self — and the type answered it by *tearing*: refusal, public, stationary; the Hunted Outlaw's founding scene was a *deed* — an act written by the self — and the type answered it by *flight*: escape, private, mobile — the test: hand each of them the *pardon*. The Fate-Breaker declines it as a script — the decree, forbidden, even when kind.

The Outlaw calculates it like a *trap* — the pardon, being a *proceeding*, requiring the self to *appear* — and the border, the chapter's sharpest: *the Fate-Breaker refuses the verdict the world hands her; the Hunted Outlaw flees the verdict he wrote himself* — and the chase log's closing note: the two types are freedom's two instruments — the *no* and the *gone* — and each, the whole file will show, holds half the medicine: the Outlaw has the mobility the Fate-Breaker lacks, and the Fate- Breaker has the *standing* the Outlaw has never once risked — the self, planted, and the question, *faced* — the one courtroom the road cannot outrun.

The *Relentless Avenger* (Volume 9) is the mirror confusion, the pursuit log's most *symmetrical*, because both types are defined by a *deed* and both run on it: but the Avenger's deed was done *to* the self: the wrong, the trespass, the violation — the campaign, *inbound*: justice, pursued; the Hunted Outlaw's deed was done *by* the self: the act, the offense, the flight — the campaign, *outbound*: consequence, *dodged* — the test: ask each what the trail behind them holds. The Avenger answers in *pursuit* — the debt, still owed, the wrongdoer, still findable. The Outlaw answers in *flight* — the debt, still *carried*, the pursuer, still assumed — and the border, the chapter's final entry: *the Avenger is the posse; the Outlaw is the pursued* — two selves, mirror-shaped, running on the same energy from opposite sides of the law — and the pursuit log's closing note, the symmetry the shelf loves: the Avenger's war can end in a *verdict* — the wrong, answered, the balance restored; the Outlaw's flight has no such closing event, because the verdict it flees is the *self's own* — no one can acquit the type from outside — which is why the mature file's verdict differs so sharply from the young type's plan: the escape is not won by another town; it is won the day the self stops, turns around, and *holds the trial* — and the whole file will show: the road was never the freedom; the *closed case* was.

And the signature file closes with the one field check the chase log saves for the witnesses who have known the type longest, because the tell does not live in the restaurants or the job changes — it lives in the *packing*: the Hunted Outlaw, the pursuit log has confirmed it in case after case, keeps a bag by the door — packed, current, the papers in the side pocket — through years in which no pursuit existed and no departure was scheduled — and the type, asked about it, laughs and calls it *habit*, and the chase log's note: the habit is

the biography — the bag maintained the way other selves maintain gardens, tended, current, *ready*, and never once opened in anger or in peace.

The check extends to the farewell tenses, and the pursuit log collects these too: the compliment, paid by the type in rooms the type is not leaving — *you were great to know*, said over a drink in a bar the type will return to next week — and the chase log's finding, entered without judgment because the type means nothing by it: the type speaks in farewell tenses the way the settled speak in future tenses — each sentence of praise delivered *pre-nostalgically*, embalmed at the moment of feeling, because feeling, in the type's grammar, is safest in the past tense, where it cannot be *collected as evidence*.

And the pursuit log's last signature check, the one the chase log asks the reader to run quietly on the next Hunted Outlaw they meet: watch the phone — the type does not save numbers; the type *memorizes* them — the contacts list kept short enough to survive a customs check, the important numbers carried in the head like contraband, and the finding underneath the habit: a saved number is an *admission* — a record, discoverable, *subpoena-able* — while a memorized one is testimony held in the only vault no warrant can open — and so the type's affections, all of them, are stored in the one place the world cannot seize and the type cannot *lose on purpose* — and the chase log's closing note on the signature, entered with the tenderness the indictment has earned by now: the bag by the door is not the type's escape plan; it is the type's *portrait* — a self painted in what is ready to leave — and the reader who has clocked the exits and the farewell tenses and the memorized numbers has read the whole biography in one hallway, and the pursuit log's one-line sketch for the margins: *the Hunted Outlaw says goodbye fluently and hello expertly, and the sentence the type has never once been heard to say, in any town, in any alias, in twenty years of testimony: I live here.*

End of free sample. The full book is available at putrabooks.github.io